



Above Plaza Mayor, Madrid's principal square, abounds in historic buildings and sidewalk restaurants

A Day in Madrid

When Madrid became the capital in 1561, Spain's monarchs went to work transforming the sleepy regional city into the gleaming seat of the crown. From monumental plazas to broad boulevards, and masterpieces of Spanish art to elegant garden parks, their legacies remain some of the most engaging sights of the city.

MORNING View wondrous renditions of the royal family by Diego Velázquez in the **Museo del Prado** — created when the crown transferred much of its collection to this public museum. Then stroll the gardens of the **Parque del Buen Retiro**, once a royal retreat.

AFTERNOON Ringed with cafés and restaurants, **Plaza Mayor** has been Madrid's central gathering spot since it was completed in 1619. Leave this bustling realm of the people to spend hours getting a glimpse of the royal lifestyle in the **Palacio Real**.

EVENING Dress for the red carpet to attend a concert, recital, opera, or ballet in the **Teatro Real**, the 19th-century jewel-box concert hall ordered by Queen Isabel II.

Essentials

GETTING THERE

Most international airlines fly into **Madrid-Barajas Airport**, 7 miles (12 km) from downtown. There are **buses**, **metro trains**, and shared and standard **taxis** to the central city. Use the fantastic metro to get around the city.

WHERE TO STAY

Hostal Macarena (inexpensive) has spacious but simple rooms near Plaza Mayor. www.silserranos.com

Hotel Moderno (moderate) is a gracious family-run property. www.hotel-moderno.com

Husa Hotel Paseo del Arte (expensive) is a sleek, stylish hotel near the Reina Sofía art museum. www.hotelhusapaseodelarte.com

TOURIST INFORMATION

Plaza Mayor 27; +34 915 881 636; www.esmadrid.com



Above *Cocido madrileño* traditionally includes a mixture of salt meat, fresh meat, and smoked sausages, made tender by slow cooking